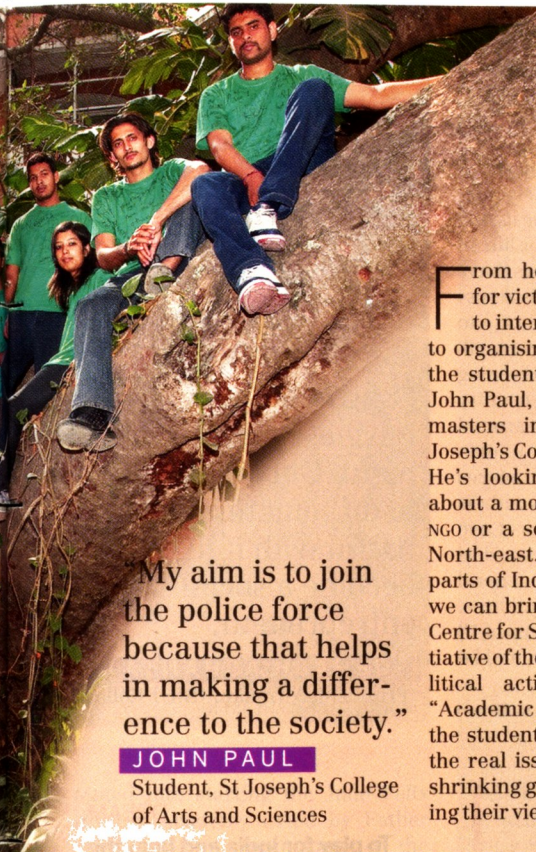




Student Activists *Bangalore*

Agents of Change

DREAM

To sensitise the youth on environmental and social issues

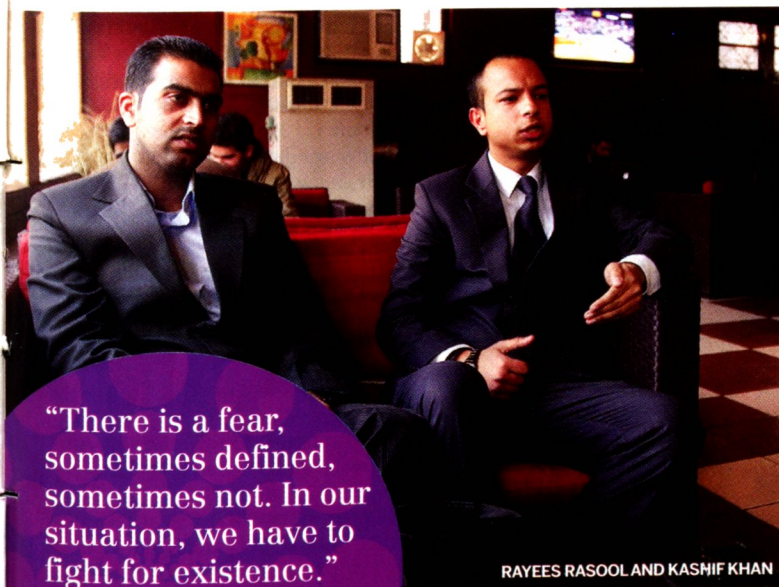
"My aim is to join the police force because that helps in making a difference to the society."

JOHN PAUL

Student, St Joseph's College of Arts and Sciences

From holding a candlelight vigil for victims of Bhopal gas tragedy to interacting with AIDS survivors to organising blood donation camps, the students have done it all. Take John Paul, 23, currently pursuing a masters in social work from St Joseph's College of Arts and Sciences. He's looking forward to spending about a month or two working in an NGO or a social action group in the North-east. "It is good to see most parts of India and see what changes we can bring about," he says. At the Centre for Social Concern (CSC), an initiative of the 126-year-old college, political action is a way of life. "Academic excellence aside, we want the students to get more involved in the real issues like global warming, shrinking green layer or just expressing their views on death penalty," says

Principal Father Ambrose Pinto. Recently, Paul and his group of student-activists helped the CSC organise a solidarity walk on key roads of the state capital. They also held a public hearing on police torture on the college premises which was attended by former judge of the Bombay High Court, Justice H. Suresh. All this might sound impressive, but the students are still far from being satisfied. They are here, as they say, to create a social revolution in every way. Beulah Eden, 23, says eco-consciousness must start young. "It will grow on you when it is nurtured in campus settings like ours," she says. Pointing to the sprawling banyan tree in the forecourt, the principal says college should be a place where ideas germinate, strike roots, grow tall and nourish a new generation. **by Stephen David**



"There is a fear, sometimes defined, sometimes not. In our situation, we have to fight for existence."

RAYEES RASOOL Founder, iGear Solutions

RAYEES RASOOL AND KASHIF KHAN

YASIN DAR

himself. If people wouldn't come to Kashmir, they would take Kashmir to the world. As they sit now in a warm Srinagar café on a chilly winter day, Khan and Rasool, trained as engineers in Jammu and Pune, bubble with enthusiasm. While Khan has founded his own company, Resolute Consultancy Services, Rasool has started iGear Solutions. Their confidence stems from their own professional competence. "We're trying to create opportunities not just for ourselves but for others. We should not be judged by a political yardstick," says Khan. The government for them is not a provider of employment but a potential customer. And though they tried to partner with the state in its ambitious e-governance project with no success, they have taken on the J&K Bank's Khidmat centre, connecting a 1,000 village branches. Their Kashmiri identity may be a baggage but they are learning to travel light. **by Aijaz Hussain**